

Episode 15: Once Upon a Time... (10) Still More Collaborative Works, Then Suddenly

It's early summer. The weather's decent and the sunshine feels pleasant and refreshing. The air is crisp, and even when you sweat a bit, it dries right up - GOOD.

So I'm already in short-sleeve T-shirt mode this season. When it gets even hotter, I won't have any more clothes to wear... I think this every year, but when next month brings the rainy season, it gets relatively cool. Well, before that, I need to be careful not to collapse from the humidity.

I want to play outside lots before that rainy season comes... (distant stare).
Well then.

Let me set aside the paint talk for now.

Having become able to do colour direction for collaborative works, I first got the mini-series *Robotex* and somehow managed to finish it. Of the total 5 episodes, I was able to do colour direction and check deliveries for 2 or 3 episodes... Even now I can't remember the story details (bitter laugh), but this became my first colour direction work.

Around the same time as *Robotex* production, I handled several collaborative works as per-episode colour director. First was *Transformers*. You know, trucks and trains that transform into robots. That work feels very Japanese-made now, but this was also American collaboration. Specifically, which series and which episodes I did - I can't tell anymore, but I handled several episodes.

"Can't tell anymore..." because we were making so many, year after year. Not just *Transformers* but series like *G.I. Joe* and *Muppet Babies*, starting production around

summer each year to match American broadcast schedules, making about 50 episodes per series annually.

So, *Transformers*. Man, it was robot stuff (bitter laugh). Robot stuff, but somehow very human-like - well, the robots talked and acted (laughs). I've forgotten the stories too, but my impression was some cube or other, a pink or purple cube glowing with transmitted light, with flashy beam battles over it.

Honestly, the animation was quite loose, so the moving images weren't particularly cool, and I remember not enjoying it that much... (bitter laugh). Though last year I got hooked on robot stuff with *Gaiking: Legend of Daiku-Maryu* (ガイキング *LEGEND OF DAIKU-MARYU*) (laughs).

Oh yes, speaking of *Transformers*, Toei Doga was making a theatrical version around then. Directed by **Morishita Kozo** (森下孝三). I think it was about a 2-hour epic. This one had perfectly cool animation - shadows with secondary shadows plus BL shadows, of course highlights galore - incredibly dense.

For this theatrical version, I helped with checking finishing deliveries, and man, I remember it being incredibly difficult. But I thought, if this gets done properly, it'll be amazing, while somewhat detachedly checking for colour mismatches.

Later, when I saw the completed footage (I think I saw it on video, not the first print...), it was spectacular. Honestly, I've forgotten the plot of this too (explosion), but I was simply overwhelmed by the density that was completely different from the TV series *Transformers* I'd worked on. Ah, I want to see it again.

Besides per-episode *Transformers* colour direction, there were lots of small collaborative work commercials and such short projects, and I was handling those one after another.

Like this, day after day I was struggling with collaborative works that couldn't be seen in Japan, but suddenly things took a sharp turn - I ended up handling a domestic work. Moreover, it was a theatrical work!

The title was *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso* (ゲゲゲの鬼太郎妖怪大戦争).

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